THE BATTLE OF DREPANA

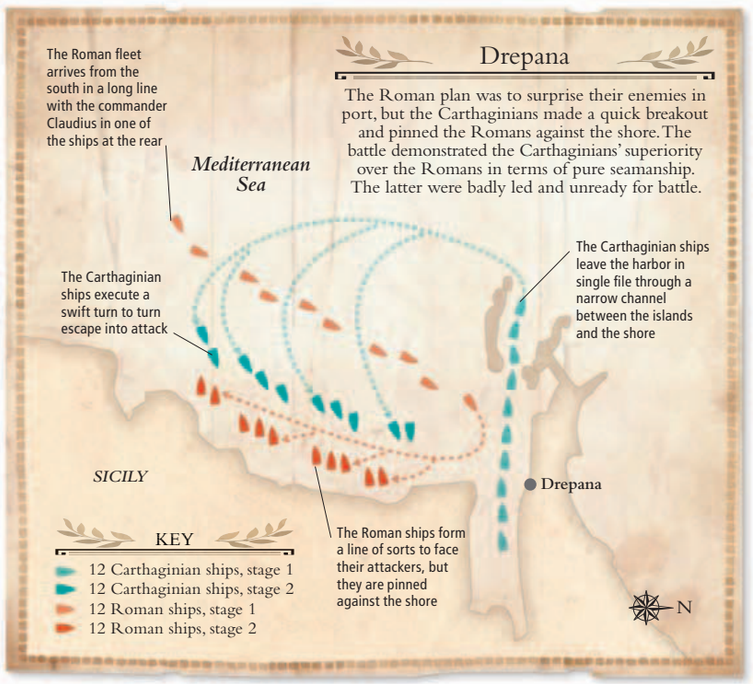
When a Roman fleet was sent to support the army in a siege of the coastal stronghold of Lilybaeum, the Carthaginians sailed reinforcements to the fortress right under the noses of the Romans, repeatedly running ships into Lilybaeum from their nearby base at Drepana. The Romans eventually managed to seal the blockade, but they wanted to avenge these humiliations.

One of the consuls for 249, Publius Claudius Pulcher, decided to launch a surprise raid on Drepana with ships and marines. The Roman fleet sailed up the coast at night, but this led to its losing formation. Dawn found a straggling line of galleys approaching Drepana, with Claudius's flagship well to the rear. Fearing he would be pinned in harbor, the Carthaginian admiral, Adherbal, boldly set to sea as soon as the Romans were sighted.

Meanwhile Claudius performed one of the most important functions of any Roman leader: he sought evidence of the support of the gods. Sacred chickens were carried on board for the purpose. If they were happy, divine support in battle could be expected. Ominously, when offered grain, the birds sulkily refused to eat. Instead of canceling the battle, Claudius had the chickens thrown into the sea, explaining with an irreverent quip that if they would not eat, perhaps they would drink.

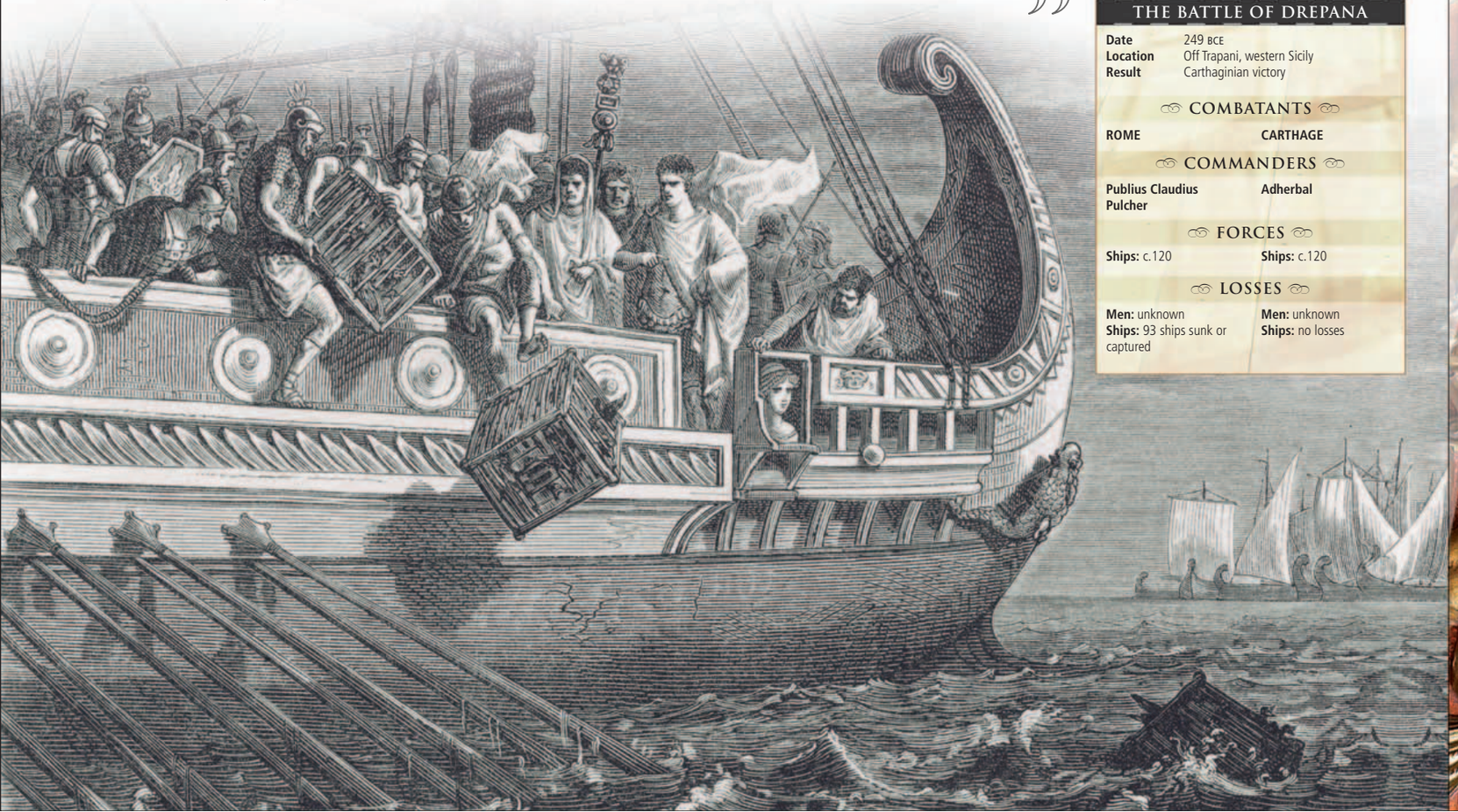
CARTHAGINIAN TRIUMPH

Adherbal skilfully led his ships out to sea, rounding two islands at the northern end of the harbor mouth as the first Roman ships were entering the harbor from the south. Claudius realized what they were doing, but had difficulty communicating with his leading galleys. After a period of confusion, in which several ships collided, the Romans were organized into a line with their sterns to the coast, facing the Carthaginians who had swiftly rowed round to attack shoreward. The Punic crews used their rams with deadly efficiency against the cornered Roman ships, many of which ran aground trying to avoid being sunk. Claudius escaped with around 30 ships; the rest were lost. When he returned to Rome Claudius was put on trial and exiled, with his cavalier treatment of the sacred chickens topping the list of his misdemeanors.



A moment of pride and folly
Publius Claudius Pulcher commits the sacrilege of ordering the drowning of the sacred chickens. These were carried aboard Roman ships so their behavior could be analyzed by the priests.

> "HE ONLY RIDICULED THE GODS IN JEST, BUT THE MOCKERY COST HIM DEAR, FOR HIS FLEET WAS UTTERLY ROUTED ..."
>
> **CICERO** ON PUBLIUS CLAUDIUS PULCHER'S TREATMENT OF THE SACRED CHICKENS



THE FIRST PUNIC WAR



THE BATTLE OF DREPANA

Date	249 BCE
Location	Off Trapani, western Sicily
Result	Carthaginian victory

COMBATANTS

ROME	CARTHAGE

COMMANDERS

Publius Claudius Pulcher	Adherbal

FORCES

Ships: c.120	**Ships:** c.120

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** 93 ships sunk or captured	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** no losses